



Close on the heels of the LAMP development platform is WAMP. Read on to learn the right steps to install and set it up. This article also outlines a few of the typical problems faced and offers some troubleshooting tips.

LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL and PHP) is a very popular development platform in the open source world. Many mission critical websites are developed on this platform to leverage the best of the three open source technologies. WAMP extends this platform further to the Microsoft Windows open source community. While the installation is straightforward on Windows, sometimes it gets tricky to set up WAMP and use it for serious software development.

What is WAMP?

WAMP stands for Windows, Apache, MySQL and PHP. It is a consolidated package designed to install smoothly on almost any Windows operating system. Needless to say, WAMP has Apache as a Web server, MySQL as the open source backend database engine, and a stack of PHP, Perl and Python script compilers to provide the necessary programming language support. There is also a similar flavour on Mac, called MAMP. The Apache Web server is an open source replacement for Microsoft IIS server, while the MySQL engine replaces the need for Microsoft or any other commercial database engine. The beauty of the WAMP installation is that every component can be individually upgraded without the need to uninstall and reinstall the entire installation stack.

Why WAMP?

WAMP, being an open source platform, doesn't need any commercial licence, thus making it the most cost-effective and the quickest way of getting a programming platform ready. The Windows machine on which the WAMP is to be installed, however, needs a Microsoft licence. This doesn't diminish the power of WAMP in terms of programmability, ease of use or performance. Typically, the main purpose of a WAMP server is to run test applications before being uploaded on to the actual server. Similar to LAMP, it has PHPMyAdmin to manage the database engine. And it also comes with a built-in GUI interface, which lets you fine tune the installation without touching sensitive settings and configurations.

Installing WAMP

You can download an authentic copy of the WAMP server from www.wampserver.com. Depending upon your operating system, you need to choose a 32-bit or 64-bit installation pack. Since the installation has a fairly small footprint, there are no special pre-requisites for it. The installation itself is very straightforward and is entirely driven by the GUI interface. Besides choosing the default browser and selecting the install path, there is not much else, in terms of installation.

After installation, it is usually a good idea to test it. Here are a few tips on how to go about it. First check the